

How Text and WhatsApp Job Scams Really Work

A Recruiter's Field Guide

Written by a recruiter with eight years on the hiring side. These scams take one of two things from you, your money or your identity. This guide teaches you to spot both before you lose either. Sources are the FTC and FBI, listed at the end.

The one lesson that explains all of it. These scams never charge you to apply. They charge you after you believe you are already hired and already earning. Your guard is down because the money ask never looks like an application fee. That is why smart people of every age fall for it.

How a task scam moves, start to finish

Read these six steps once and you will recognize the pattern instantly the next time it lands on your phone.

- 1. The cold open.** An unexpected text, WhatsApp, or Telegram message from a recruiter offering remote work, usually with a daily or weekly pay rate and almost no real job details. Sometimes they only ask you to reply YES or INTERESTED.
- 2. The easy job.** You are told to do simple repetitive tasks: liking videos, rating products, or product boosting and optimization in an app or web platform.
- 3. The fake earnings.** A dashboard shows your earnings climbing with every task. They may even send you a small real payout, often five to twenty dollars, to make it feel real and earn your trust.
- 4. The flip.** To unlock the next set of tasks, or to withdraw your earnings, the app tells you to deposit your own money, usually in crypto. Sometimes your balance is pushed negative so you have to deposit just to finish a set.
- 5. The escalation.** You deposit to free the earnings you can see. It is never enough. They demand more, drop you into group chats where fake experienced workers share success stories, and near the end ask for a final tax or withdrawal fee.
- 6. The vanish.** You never get the earnings or your deposits back. The money, usually crypto, is gone and hard to trace.

Why it works: the climbing dashboard is manufactured proof, the small real payout builds trust, and once you have deposited, the fear of losing it keeps you chasing. The FTC notes the whole thing is built like a slot machine.

The fake-check variant, the check that clears, then does not

- You are hired and mailed a check to cover equipment or first expenses, always for more than you need.

- You are told to deposit it and send back the excess, by Zelle, Cash App, a crypto ATM, or gift cards.
- Banks must make the funds available within a day or two, so the money looks real in your account, and you send your real money on.
- Days later the check is found to be counterfeit, the bank pulls the full amount back out of your account, and the scammer keeps what you sent.

The trap. There is a gap between funds available and check actually cleared. They are not the same thing, and scammers count on you not knowing that.

The identity-harvest variant, when they take your identity, not your cash

Not every job scam is after your money. Some are after you. This one looks more like a real hiring process, which is what makes it dangerous.

- After a long fake interview, the company asks for your Social Security number, date of birth, and bank account, supposedly to set up direct deposit.
- With those details they open credit cards, take out loans, or file false tax returns in your name.
- The cost shows up later as fraud charges and months of cleanup, long after the fake job is gone.

This is why even a free application can hurt you. If you hand sensitive details to a fake employer, you have given away the keys, and no money ever had to change hands for it to cost you.

The red flags, in plain English

- They contacted you out of nowhere. You never applied.
- The pay is high and the work is vague: liking, rating, boosting, optimizing.
- Hiring happens entirely on WhatsApp, Telegram, or a personal email, not a company address.
- You are asked to deposit money, recharge a balance, or pay to unlock or withdraw your earnings.
- A check you must deposit and then send part of it back.
- You are asked for your Social Security number, bank account, or a photo of your ID before any real interview.
- You are told to pay up front for training, equipment, certification, or a background check.
- Pressure to act fast, and group chats full of success stories.

The one rule that never fails

If money has to flow from you, in any form, it is a scam. Walk away. A real employer will never ask you to pay to get a job, pay to get paid, deposit a check and send part of it back, or buy your own equipment before you start. And real recruiters do not hire you cold over text, WhatsApp, or Telegram.

What to do if you are already in one

- Stop depositing immediately.
- Contact your bank or the payment app right away. They may be able to stop or flag the money.
- If you shared your Social Security number or bank details, place a free fraud alert or freeze on your credit.
- Report it to the FTC at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov** and to the FBI at **ic3.gov**. Reporting helps, even when recovery is hard.
- Save everything, the messages, the app, the payment records, as evidence.

Sources

FTC and FBI materials are US government works and are free to quote. FTC Job Scams overview at consumer.ftc.gov/all-scams/job-scams. FTC on gamified task scams and record losses. FTC alerts on task scams and fake checks. FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center at ic3.gov. Report fraud at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.

How Aplyer fits. This guide teaches you to spot the scams that arrive by text and message. Aplyer does not stop those, because they never come through a job application. What Aplyer does is help you put your real effort into real jobs, by checking a posting before you apply and writing your application answers in your own voice.